

New Homeowner Maintenance Guide — Action Checklist

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MAP YOUR SEASONAL TASKS

- ☐ **Create a seasonal maintenance calendar listing tasks for each quarter and schedule your first roof inspection before spring rains arrive so you catch winter damage while it is still fixable.:** Create a seasonal maintenance calendar listing tasks for each quarter and schedule your first roof inspection before spring rains arrive so you catch winter damage while it is still fixable.
- ☐ **Book your furnace inspection in September before the October scheduling rush because a \$150 inspection can prevent a \$3,000 emergency replacement during the coldest months of January.:** Book your furnace inspection in September before the October scheduling rush because a \$150 inspection can prevent a \$3,000 emergency replacement during the coldest months of January.
- ☐ **Test smoke and carbon monoxide detectors every spring and fall while replacing batteries so these life-saving devices never fail when you and your family are sleeping.:** Test smoke and carbon monoxide detectors every spring and fall while replacing batteries so these life-saving devices never fail when you and your family are sleeping.
- ☐ **Identify and document your main water shutoff valve location now so you can respond within seconds if a frozen pipe bursts and prevent catastrophic water damage.:** Identify and document your main water shutoff valve location now so you can respond within seconds if a frozen pipe bursts and prevent catastrophic water damage.

USE THE REPAIR TRIAGE

- ☐ **Before calling anyone for a repair, first determine whether the situation is dangerous by checking for gas leaks, smoke, fire, or structural hazards that require immediate evacuation.:** Before calling anyone for a repair, first determine whether the situation is dangerous by checking for gas leaks, smoke, fire, or structural hazards that require immediate evacuation.
- ☐ **If your repair issue is not immediately dangerous, assess whether it is actively worsening and call a licensed plumber or structural expert for same-day service if water is involved.:** If your repair issue is not immediately dangerous, assess whether it is actively worsening and call a licensed plumber or structural expert for same-day service if water is involved.

- ☐ **Get written estimates for any contractor work exceeding \$200 and refuse verbal quotes entirely, as documented agreements protect you from surprise charges and scope changes.:** Get written estimates for any contractor work exceeding \$200 and refuse verbal quotes entirely, as documented agreements protect you from surprise charges and scope changes.
- ☐ **Before hiring any contractor, verify their license and insurance independently through your state licensing board and request three recent local references to call directly.:** Before hiring any contractor, verify their license and insurance independently through your state licensing board and request three recent local references to call directly.

PREPARE YOUR FUNDS

- ☐ **Set aside one to three percent of your home purchase price as an emergency reserve to cover realistic year-one costs that include HVAC servicing, roof patching, and plumbing callouts.:** Set aside one to three percent of your home purchase price as an emergency reserve to cover realistic year-one costs that include HVAC servicing, roof patching, and plumbing callouts.
- ☐ **Budget for five common first-year expenses including HVAC servicing at \$150 to \$400, roof patching at \$300 to \$1,200, and plumbing callouts at \$150 to \$600 per visit.:** Budget for five common first-year expenses including HVAC servicing at \$150 to \$400, roof patching at \$300 to \$1,200, and plumbing callouts at \$150 to \$600 per visit.
- ☐ **Obtain a minimum of three written bids from licensed contractors for any repair exceeding \$2,000 to ensure you are comparing competitive pricing and not overpaying.:** Obtain a minimum of three written bids from licensed contractors for any repair exceeding \$2,000 to ensure you are comparing competitive pricing and not overpaying.
- ☐ **Insist on a deposit of no more than 25 to 33 percent upfront and require the remaining payment upon completion to protect yourself from unfinished or abandoned work.:** Insist on a deposit of no more than 25 to 33 percent upfront and require the remaining payment upon completion to protect yourself from unfinished or abandoned work.